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POPE LEO XIV MEETS PARTICIPANTS MARKING ANTI-DRUG DAY

■ Pope Leo XIV meets with participants marking the International Day Against Drug Abuse and Illicit Trafficking, in the St Damasus courtyard at the Vatican, yesterday. This is the first time the Pope has interacted with crowds up close since taking over. The day was observed worldwide with several events including destruction of confiscated illegal drugs and launch of various strategies to prevent drug use.

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UAE among world's best tourism economies

Ranks among top 7 for international tourist spending

DUBAI

BY KHITAM AL AMIR
Chief News Editor

The UAE has cemented its position among the world's leading tourism economies, ranking among the top seven global destinations for international tourist spending, according to new data from the World Travel and Tourism Council.

His Highness Shaikh Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Vice-President and

Dh217b

Total spending
by international
visitors last year

Prime Minister of the UAE and Ruler of Dubai, described the achievement as a new milestone in the nation's economic journey.

"In a new indicator of the strength and diversity of our national economy, the World Travel and Tourism Council highlighted exceptional achievements in the UAE's

tourism sector," Shaikh Mohammed wrote in a post on his official X account.

"Total spending by international visitors exceeded Dh217 billion last year, with an additional Dh57 billion spent by domestic tourists."

Stellar year ahead

The report from WTTC also forecasts another stellar year for the UAE's travel and tourism sector in 2025, with an anticipated contribution of Dh267.5 billion to the national economy. This impressive figure is expected to account for almost 13 per cent of the country's Gross Domestic Product (GDP).

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US dollar slump to affect UAE remittances

GREENBACK DECLINES TO ITS LOWEST LEVEL IN OVER THREE YEARS

DUBAI

BY JUSTIN VARGHESE
Your Money Editor

The US dollar slumped to its lowest level in over three years after reports suggested President Donald Trump could fast-track the appointment of a new Federal Reserve chair, fuelling market expectations of quicker interest rate cuts.

A Bloomberg index tracking the greenback dropped 0.5 per cent on Tuesday — its weakest level since April 2022. The shift follows growing speculation that Trump could announce a replacement for current Fed Chair Jerome Powell as early as September, well ahead of the scheduled end of Powell's term in 2026.

Potential replacements for Powell include Fed governor Kevin Warsh and National Economic Council director Kevin Hassett, alongside US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent and Fed Governor Chris Waller, reported multiple media outlets.

"The discussion around naming a Fed chair early — and that chair being more dovish or willing to align with Trump's preference for rate cuts — is weighing on the dollar," said Timothy Graf, head of EMEA macro strategy at State Street Global Markets.

US stock markets, alongside other markets worldwide tracking the world's largest economy to set the direction of their respective monetary policies, are now pricing in 63 basis points of

10%

decline in the US dollar's value so far this year

interest rate cuts from the Fed by year-end, up from 51 basis points just last week.

Expats may need to hold off

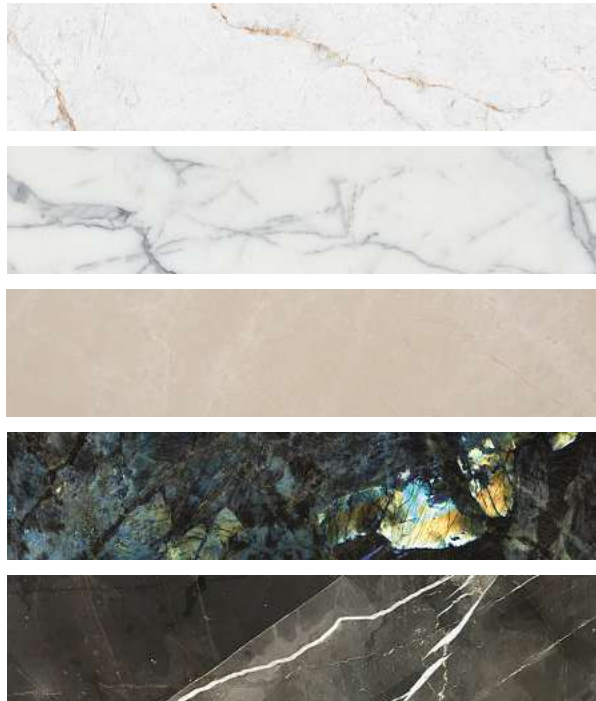
The weakening dollar is already changing the outlook for remittances from the UAE, especially for Asian expats. Just earlier this week, the Indian rupee and Philippine peso had weakened to levels last seen in April — a favourable window for remitting money home. Now, with the dollar weakening again, those same expats may need to hold off. "If the dollar drops further, it may make sense to send only part of your remittance now, and wait to see if the greenback stabilises," currency analysts advised.

The latest declines left the greenback down more than 10 per cent for the year. If it stays that way in the coming days it will be its biggest first-half-of-a-year fall since the early 1970s — effectively the era of free-floating currencies. For now, the combination of political uncertainty, rate cut bets, and global inflation worries suggest continued volatility in currency markets.

— with inputs from Agencies

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